



Software enforcers

AntiRSI, Timeout, and Workrave force you in not-so-subtle ways to take a break and engage in stress relief exercises

Kinesis advantage

A completely split keyboard that is ergonomically designed and features a Dvorak optional layout instead of the regular QWERTY layout

In touch with Ergonomics

Agent 001 scours the streets for the best ergonomic devices money can buy. Here's the dope on ergonomics and whether the so called ergonomic devices out there are really worth it

Agent 001

agent001@thinkdigit.com

Recently a friend of mine, who's used to cribbing, was complaining a lot about wrist pain and all sorts of other "stress" related afflictions while we were chatting. Initially, I dismissed it as him being his usual whiny self until I realised the magnitude of his problem. Could this be Carpal tunnel syndrome or repetitive stress disorder caused by working in a non ergonomic or human friendly environment? There could be many more people out there who could use some guidance when it comes to ergonomic devices reducing the chances of injury when using a computer for long hours. Confused? Let me explain.

By and large, ergonomics tries to improve human interactions with products, equipment, environments and systems. It takes into account human biology, stress analysis and material engineering to make products more usable and less stressful to the human body during repetitive use. Simply put, that's making products keeping the end user and usage in mind. Ideally, all devices should be ergonomic. But in reality, only a small percentage are.

So, keeping the risks of RSI in mind, I went out on a quest to find out what

ergonomic input devices and aids are available out there. Lamington road – the hardware capital of our country – turned out to be somewhat of a disappointment. My hardship began with explaining the product category to the guys behind the counter. They were better versed with gaming mice and keyboards – Salmosa and Steel Series being the most sought – than ergonomic devices. But after a bit of shop to shop hunting, model number quoting and describing such devices, two boxes were



specially unearthed and called for. One was the Logitech MK 700 wireless keyboard. Though not strictly an ergonomic keyboard it did have scalloped keys, which according to the Logitech "position your fingers properly, and their softly rounded edges invite your fingertips to glide from key to key". This one was available for around Rs. 4,500 and I'm certain will improve typing accuracy if not give you ergonomic comfort. The

other keyboard + mouse set that was shown to me, was the Microsoft Natural Series 7000. This one was an ergonomic keyboard in the true sense of the word. It featured a 12 degree split down the middle (roughly between the T and Y set of keys) and a 14 degree gable. A gable can be thought of as a sloping bump on the keyboard with its peak roughly at the centre. The mouse had a thumb rest contour which takes away weight from the side of the palm and other carpal tunnel stress points. It feels

like you are holding a blob that is adjusted to the space naturally formed when you close your palm. I found the mouse to be way more comfortable than standard mice. But with a price tag as much as its model number, it remains a significant decision, which could prove useful in the long run. Also of interest, though not strictly ergonomic was my old favourite – the TV Gold mechanical keyboard available for around Rs. 1,100.

Other than keyboards and mice there are other ergonomic aids on offer in the form of gel-filled keyboard rests and mouse pads. These are available for around Rs. 200 and offer support when using devices that are not ergonomic. However my personal experience with them has not been up to the mark. The gel does give tactile support but it's almost always a little higher than you'd normally want.

To conclude, I would urge everyone to seriously consider doing whatever little they can from improving posture to exercises and keep your body stress free. **d**



Illustration: Binesh PS

ERGONOMIC FURNITURE



injuries. Ergonomic furniture is designed in such a way that your posture automatically improves. You sit and work in a way that is

Apart from ergonomic input devices, the furniture you sit on and house your computer, goes a long way to avoid repetitive stress

most natural. There should be no forward flexion of the neck, twisting of the torso. While adequate lumbar (back) support should be provided. There are furniture attachment modules that are separately available too, such as a negative tilt keyboard tray that lets you tilt the keyboard away from you, leaving your wrist drop to its most natural or neutral position. So the next time you custom make a computer table or go out to buy one, be sure to consider these principles.